Policy 03 — Self-Exclusion

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Safer Gambling Lead
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	Annually
Relates to	LCCP social responsibility code 3.5.3 (self-exclusion, remote), and 3.5.6 (multi-operator self-exclusion — see Policy 04); marketing restrictions for self-excluded customers

> Draft for review by a compliance adviser. LCCP references to be confirmed against the current version.

1. Purpose

Self-exclusion lets a customer stop themselves gambling with PlayStake for a period they choose. The period can't be undone while it runs. This policy explains:

- how customers self-exclude
- what happens while they are excluded
- how exclusion ends
- how the platform makes sure an excluded customer cannot gamble with us or be marketed to

It also covers the shorter **cool-off** break, which works in the same way for a shorter time. Participation in the national scheme, GAMSTOP, is covered in Policy 04.

2. Periods offered

Option	Periods
Self-exclusion	6 months, 1 year, 2 years, 5 years
Cool-off (take a break)	24 hours, 72 hours, 1 week, 1 month, 6 weeks

The minimum self-exclusion is six months.

3. How customers self-exclude

- **Self-service:** from **Safer Gambling** in their account, available from every page in the account area.
  - The customer picks a period.
  - A confirmation screen explains in plain English:
    - what happens

        - that the exclusion cannot be shortened or lifted early by the customer or by our staff
        - that they can still sign in and withdraw their balance
        - that anything waiting in a lobby, and any challenges, will be withdrawn
        - that when the period ends the account stays closed to gambling until they ask to return
    - The customer must confirm before the exclusion starts.
- **By contacting us:**
    - A customer can ask by email (support@playstake.org) or any other contact.
    - Staff apply it straight away from the customer's admin page, recording how the customer asked.
    - This is audited, and the same rules apply as for self-service.
    - Staff must never try to talk a customer out of self-excluding.
- **Confirmation:** the customer gets an email confirming the exclusion and its end date, with GamCare's details.
- **Signposting:** the Safer Gambling page tells customers about GAMSTOP, so they can exclude from every UK-licensed online operator at once, and gives the contact details for GamCare (0808 8020 133) and BeGambleAware.

4. What happens during self-exclusion

From the moment a self-exclusion starts:

1. **No gambling.** Every deposit, stake and game entry passes the eligibility check (Master Manual §5.1). A self-excluded customer is refused at each of:

    - depositing
    - joining a lobby
    - sending an invite
    - accepting an invite or challenge
    - issuing a challenge
    - starting a free-to-play game

2. **Open activity is withdrawn.** The following are cancelled at once, so they cannot be drawn into a match:

    - the customer's waiting lobby entries
    - invites they have received
    - challenges they have sent or received

    Nothing needs refunding at this point, because stakes are only taken once a match is agreed.

3. **They can't be pulled into a match by someone else.** If another player tries to accept a challenge from a customer who has since self-excluded, the platform re-checks the customer before taking their stake, and refuses. The other player is told only that the player "isn't available". The reason is never disclosed.

4. **Matches already agreed** before the exclusion run to their normal end and settle as usual. Voiding them would unfairly affect the opponent.

5. **Withdrawals stay open.** The customer can still sign in and withdraw their whole balance at any time. On request, staff close the account and return the balance.

6. **No marketing or optional emails.** While any break is in force, the customer receives only essential emails (security, payments, responsible play). They get no promotional email even if they previously consented to it (including emails when a streamer they follow goes live), no optional notifications, and no in-app go-live alerts. They are also hidden from player search and their profile can't be viewed or followed, so other players can't find them and invite them to play. The same applies to customers registered with GAMSTOP and to restricted accounts.

7. **No early end.** The exclusion cannot be shortened or lifted by the customer or by staff. The platform only allows it to be replaced by a longer one.

8. **It follows the person.** If the excluded customer opens another account, the new account's identity documents are matched to them at verification. The same exclusion is applied to the new account automatically, and a case is opened for staff to review (Policy 01 §3.2).

5. How self-exclusion ends

A self-exclusion does **not** lapse on its own:

1. When the period ends, the customer is emailed. The email explains that their account **stays closed to gambling**, that nothing changes unless they choose to come back, how to return if they want to, and where to get support.
2. To return, the customer must take a **positive action**: asking to return from Safer Gambling and confirming it.
3. Access then resumes after a **24-hour cooling-off period**. During that time the account stays closed, and the page shows when it reopens. The customer is encouraged to set deposit limits first.

A cool-off ends automatically at the end of its period, and the customer is emailed when it does.

6. Staff responsibilities

The Safer Gambling Lead is responsible for:

- applying self-exclusions requested by email or phone the same day, and recording how the request arrived
- never shortening, lifting or trying to talk a customer out of a self-exclusion (the platform prevents this anyway)
- when a shared-identity case shows a new account linked to a self-excluded person, confirming the exclusion was applied, and considering whether the customer should be contacted with support information
- making sure no marketing list or promotion ever includes excluded customers (the platform enforces this for its own emails; any external or manual marketing must be filtered against the platform's exclusion data first)
- checking a sample of self-exclusions every month, to confirm they were applied correctly and no gambling or marketing followed

7. Records

- **What is kept:** self-exclusions and breaks (start, end, return request, return effective date).
- **How long:** kept even if the customer's account is later deleted, for at least 5 years after the exclusion ends.
- **Audit trail:** staff-applied exclusions appear in the admin audit log.

8. Review

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft